Sangh prayer. In between come games, physical drills, prayers and ideological discussions. A *mukhya shikshak* (chief instructor) runs each shakha. Weekly *milans* and monthly *mandalis* (gatherings) serve the places that have no daily shakhas. The RSS requires no formal membership application. Regular attendance creates the relationship.

Longer training then identifies future organisers and connects them with experienced leaders. Swayamsevaks climb a ladder of residential camps of various durations. The camps teach volunteers how to run branches, discuss the Sangh's worldview and organise local service. The scale is formidable. On November 4, the RSS reported 99,423 daily shakhas, 34,982 weekly *milans* and 14,096 monthly *mandali*s, and claimed that its centenary outreach had reached more than 100 million homes.

The Seva Dal, on the other hand, had faded into oblivion over the years. The first attempts to revive it came in June 2018, when Rahul picked Gujarat activist Desai as chief organiser. Desai put an end to the practice of volunteers serving as attendants for leaders, and ensured that salutes were reserved for the national flag. Borrowing from the RSS playbook, a monthly Dhwaj Vandana, the hoisting of the tricolour, was planned across a thousand cities, and weekly Ravi Milan meetings mixed Gandhi's bhajans with debates on pluralism, unemployment and other issues. A Youth Brigade and the Dal's digital cells were other innovations.

Yet, the RSS remains way ahead in the game. Most importantly, unlike its workers, Dal volunteers rarely find a path into politics. Former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot is virtually the only one to have risen from its ranks to high office. Seva Dal's chance came with the Bharat Jodo Yatra of 2022-23, which gave it national visibility. On Rahul's 4,000-km march from Kanyakumari to Kashmir, Dal volunteers led the daily flag-hoisting, carried the tricolour at the head of the procession, and helped with local mobilisation. For once, it was seen doing more than managing party functions.

## THE NEW PLAYBOOK

Srinivas has kept Desai's foundation and added a sharper political edge. He calls his cadre the "true Babbar Shers of Rahul Gandhi" and says he is training "Seva Dal *vicharaks*", ideological communicators meant to counter the RSS's pracharaks. His two immediate goals—a stronger training system and wider recruitment among the young.

The enrolment push runs on several fronts. A membership drive is planned at block, district and state levels, aimed at young people who know little about the Congress or the Dal's history. Srinivas is also planning a nationwide tour to talk about the party's role in the freedom struggle and nation-building. An online membership portal listed 32,863 registrations across 34 geographical categories on November 3. He is tapping his old IYC network, particularly workers who stayed active without getting posts or promotions and searching the Dal's own ranks for veterans who have worked for decades without political reward. Grassroots workers, he concedes, have often been denied recognition, and giving them responsibility is a priority.



**"The objective is to transform the Seva Dal into a trained, service-oriented grassroots network that engages younger generations, responds to public needs, and has a sustained organisational presence across the country"**

**B.V. SRINIVAS**
*Chief Organiser, Seva Dal*

Service is the main recruiting tool. Under #SOSSevaDal, volunteers have run flood relief in Assam, Bihar, MP, Uttar Pradesh and Nepal, carrying out rescues and distributing food and survival kits in Assam. A programme called Seva Saathi runs health and eye camps and blood donation drives, arranges blood for patients, cleans ponds and beaches, and offers educational support and counselling to tribal children. A legal aid cell is also being planned.

However, its most distinctive experiment targets students. On the late Rajiv Gandhi's birth anniversary, Seva Dal conducted examination-style quizzes at more than 100 locations, using OMR sheets. Srinivas says thousands attended. Questions introduced the ideas of Congress while familiarising students with competitive-test conditions. The response in MP, UP, Karnataka, Kerala, Maharashtra and Telangana also helped him map where local networks were functioning and where they were weak. It was public engagement, ideological introduction and organisational reconnaissance rolled into one.

## THE 2027 TEST

What the Dal cannot yet show is scale. No verified national membership, training-camp count or deployment figure is public. Desai had claimed units in 700 districts and, by September 2021, an active membership of 370,000. Srinivas says an organisational audit is under way and expects an assessment of membership and structure by year-end.

Srinivas's real test will come in 2027, when seven states with 940 assembly seats vote. Revival drives in the 1980s, 2010 and 2018 failed to have a lasting impact. UP, Punjab, Uttarakhand, Goa and Manipur are expected to vote early in the year, Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh later. Repeating the Ramlila operation across thousands of rural booths will need sustained patronage of the AICC leadership, funds and coordination with state units and other frontal organisations. The revival will be measured not by how many workers turn up at a national rally but by how many stay active in their villages and towns between elections. ■